

Keyboard Shortcuts to Speed Up Your Work in Linux

Manipulating the mouse, keyboard and menus takes up a lot of our time, which could be saved by using keyboard shortcuts. These not only save time, but also make the computer user more efficient.

Did you realise that switching from the keyboard to the mouse while typing takes up to two seconds each time? If a person works for eight hours every day, switching from the keyboard to the mouse once a minute, and there are around 240 working days in a year, the amount of time wasted (as per calculations done by Brainscape) is:

$[2 \text{ wasted seconds/min}] \times [480 \text{ minutes per day}] \times 240 \text{ working days per year} = 64 \text{ wasted hours per year}$

This is equal to eight working days lost and hence learning keyboard shortcuts will increase productivity by 3.3 per cent (<https://www.brainscape.com/blog/2011/08/keyboard-shortcuts-economy/>).

Keyboard shortcuts provide a quicker way to do a task, which otherwise would have had to be done in multiple steps using the mouse and/or the menu. Figure 1 gives a list of a few most frequently used shortcuts in Ubuntu 18.04 Linux OS and the Web browsers. I am omitting the very well-known shortcuts like copy, paste, etc, and the ones which are not used frequently. The readers can refer to online resources for a comprehensive list of shortcuts. Note that the Windows key is renamed as Super key in Linux.

General shortcuts

A list of general shortcuts is given below.

Key combination	Action
Ctrl + Alt + T	Launches a terminal window.
Super + L or Ctrl + Alt + L	Locks the desktop.
Super + D or Ctrl + Alt + D	Displays the desktop. Pressing the same keys again will show all the windows on the desktop as these were originally.
Ctrl + Alt + Del	Displays the log-out dialogue box.
Super + A	Shows the <i>Applications</i> menu.
Ctrl + H	Displays the hidden files in the file manager. Has a toggle effect.
Alt + F1	Gives an overview of all open windows.
Alt + F2	Opens the <i>Run</i> command dialogue box.

Print Screen and video recording of the screen

The following shortcuts can be used to print the screen or take a video recording of the screen.

Key combination	Action
Print Screen	Takes a screenshot.
Alt + Print Screen	Takes a screenshot of the active window.
Ctrl + Alt + Print Screen	Takes a screenshot of a window and copies it to a clipboard.
Shift + Ctrl + Alt + R	Takes a video recording of the full screen of the desktop. The recording is done for 30 seconds, a timeframe that can be changed. During the recording, a red circle on the top right corner is displayed, and the recorded video is saved in the WebM format in the <i>Videos</i> folder of the user. Press <i>Shift+Ctrl+Alt+R</i> to stop the recording manually.

Switching between applications

The shortcut keys listed here can be used to switch between applications.

Key combination	Action
Alt + F4	Closes the currently active window.
Alt + Tab	Switches between applications.
Ctrl + Alt + Tab	Switches between applications from all workspaces.
Super + S	Switches between workspaces.
Super + W	Displays all windows in the current workspace.
Shift + Super + W	Displays all windows from all workspaces.